You Can See the Future in Changzhou

And before you ask: yes, that is a shameless riff on Leopold Aschenbrenner's, “You can see the future first in San Francisco," from *Situational Awareness*. I have returned from China to lodge a geographical objection.

And no, I don't have a trillion-dollar compute forecast or a billion-dollar AI hedge fund to sell you. At least, not yet.

So what is this about?

I went to China to see the future. Somewhere between the factories of Changzhou and the industrial parks of Suzhou, I began to wonder what it actually takes to build one of our own.

In September 2026, I spent several weeks travelling through Beijing, Shanghai and Jiangsu province, meeting entrepreneurs, researchers, government officials and industry leaders. From electric vehicle and battery factories to university laboratories, innovation centres and industrial parks, the trip offered a remarkable window into China's technological and industrial ambitions.

China is an extraordinary place to encounter the future. The scale of its infrastructure, the sophistication of its manufacturing and the breakneck speed at which technology finds its way into ordinary life can be difficult to comprehend until you see them for yourself.

But it wasn't the gimmicky robots, electric vehicles or futuristic skylines that left the deepest impression on me. It was what lay underneath the glitz.

In Changzhou, for instance, an industrial ecosystem has emerged around electric vehicles, batteries, charging infrastructure and precision manufacturing. The remarkable thing was not any single company, but how much of the surrounding economy appeared organised around making these industries succeed. Factories need suppliers, reliable electricity, skilled engineers, research institutions, capital, transport infrastructure and access to markets. China has become extraordinarily capable at assembling these complementary pieces.

The more I travelled, the more I became convinced of something that should be obvious, but is surprisingly easy to forget in today's excitement about artificial intelligence.

The future remains stubbornly physical. It always has.

Development economists and policymakers have long been enamoured with the idea that poorer economies can leapfrog stages of technological development.

For decades, the promise of technological leapfrogging has featured prominently in conversations about African development. The familiar example is how mobile phones allowed us to bypass fixed-line telecommunications. Mobile money reduced our dependence on conventional banking infrastructure. Distributed solar offers an alternative to extending expensive electricity grids into every remote community.

These are genuine advances.

But somewhere along the way, I worry that we have mistaken the ability to leapfrog particular technologies for the ability to leapfrog the foundational requirements of development itself. Rose Mutiso's “Five Rules for Technology Leapfrogging in Africa” offers a more comprehensive discussion of this distinction.

An economy cannot AGI its way out of every physical constraint.

No AI model can substitute for reliable electricity. No algorithm can transport minerals from a mine to a processing facility without roads, railways or other logistics infrastructure. We cannot automate factories that we have not built.

Indeed, the coming age of physical AI, in which intelligence moves beyond screens into factories, vehicles, robots and infrastructure, may make these foundations more important, not less.

China's technological achievements did not materialise independently of its extraordinary investments in electricity, transport, industrial capacity and urban infrastructure. Its digital economy rests on an immense physical one.

On the other hand, we cannot simply reproduce China's development trajectory. We have neither the fiscal resources nor the luxury of repeating its social and environmental mistakes. New technologies offer opportunities to build cleaner, more distributed and potentially more affordable infrastructure than previous generations could.

But **we can skip obsolete technologies, not the underlying functions they performed.**

A modern solar-and-storage system may substitute for conventional grid extension in some places. It does not eliminate the need for electricity. Digital payments can reduce dependence on physical bank branches. They do not eliminate the need for trustworthy financial institutions.

And AI, however powerful it becomes, cannot eliminate the need to build.

An African future worth building

As is evident, I've returned from China with more questions than answers, and the beginnings of a much larger research and writing project.

Over the coming weeks, I'll be developing a series of essays exploring what China's industrial transformation reveals about emerging opportunities in energy, manufacturing, infrastructure and artificial intelligence.

Most importantly, I want to investigate what any of this means for Africa.

What would it take to make our physical economies legible to machines through geospatial intelligence, smart meters, drones and other digital infrastructure? How should we finance the energy systems upon which industrialisation depends? How do we develop autonomous technologies and domestic industrial capabilities without surrendering technological sovereignty or compromising social and environmental priorities?

Above all, I want to explore what an African development model might look like if we borrowed intelligently from the rest of the world without becoming beholden to any of it.

If China taught me anything, it is that the future is not predetermined. It is the consequence of choices made, institutions built, capital deployed and, sometimes, extraordinary collective ambition (and luck).

A century from now, much of the infrastructure that looks extraordinary today will likely be obsolete. New technologies, industries and cities will have emerged. The geography of the future will have shifted once again.

Perhaps fifty years from now, you will see the future in Chegutu.